

peoples, and taking a fifth of the profits from silver mining. Settlers increasingly resisted this external interference, however, and by the 19th century the empire was diminishing as areas from Colombia to Chile won their independence.

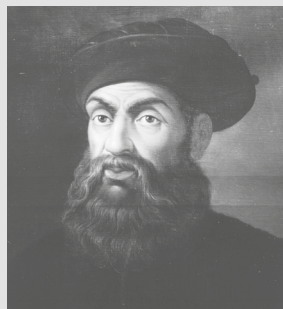
Circumnavigation

The Treaty of Tordesillas set the seal of approval on Spain's activity in America, but this deterred neither Spain nor Portugal from looking for a westward route to eastern Asia, a potential source of spices, luxury goods, and great wealth for traders from Europe. Amerigo Vespucci, an Italian navigator working for the Portuguese Crown, was one of the first to take this exploration further. He explored the coast of South America, and is remembered because the Americas are named after him. The Portuguese navigator Ferdinand Magellan was next to explore this route, this time on behalf of Spain. He believed that the Spice Islands could be less than halfway around the world when sailing west from the treaty line, which would give Spain a claim to them. In 1519 he set out with five ships in an ambitious attempt to make the first circumnavigation of the globe. Although Magellan himself died en route, some of the expedition survivors completed the voyage, giving Spain a basis for its claim to land in Southeast Asia.

In 1529 the rival Crowns signed another treaty at Zaragoza. This agreement assigned the Philippines to Spain and the Moluccas to Portugal.

The treaty's heritage

European countries not party to the Tordesillas agreement simply ignored it, and soon began to move in to develop their own empires. Britain colonized North America, for example; the Dutch moved into the Spice Islands; and several European countries set up colonies in the Caribbean. The treaty did, however, influence a significant proportion of the world. It underlined a development that was already beginning in Europe in which wealth and influence were passing from the old central European powers (based in the Holy Roman Empire) to the coastal, maritime powers that looked to build empires in new territories. These empires brought both Spain and Portugal enormous riches, and their overseas empires left a significant cultural legacy: much of South and Central America is Spanish-speaking, and there is a major Portuguese heritage in parts of Africa and Asia, the greatest of all being in Brazil. ■



Ferdinand Magellan

Born into a noble Portuguese family, Magellan (1480–1521) was orphaned as a boy, and sent to the Portuguese royal court to act as page.

As a young man, he became a naval officer. He served in Portugal's colonies in India and took part in the conquest of the Moluccas, but after a disagreement with the Portuguese king, he went to Spain to look for support for his venture westward. By 1518 he had the backing of the Spanish king Charles I, and set off the following year with five ships.

After losing one ship to the weather and another to a desertion, Magellan navigated the narrow sea route (named the Strait of Magellan in his honor) between what is now mainland South America and Tierra del Fuego. He emerged in an ocean he named Pacific, because of its calmness. He crossed this expanse of water, stopping at Guam, and then in the Philippines, where he was killed. Only one ship, under Juan Sebastian del Cano, made it back to Europe in 1522, having achieved the first circumnavigation of the globe.